

Liquid Environmental Services Operating Benchmark

Two-page benchmark brief | Analysis date: July 18, 2026 | Restaurant Technologies, Liquid Environmental Solutions, Waste Resources Management, and Wind River Environmental

SUBVERTICAL THESIS

The universe contains two structurally different models that should not be averaged. Restaurant Technologies represents an installed onsite-system model: customer-site oil equipment anchors a recurring fresh-oil, service, monitoring, and used-oil recovery relationship. LES, WRM, and Wind River represent route, collection, treatment, and processing: shared trucks, dense routes, permits, disposal access, and treatment throughput drive returns. Onsite embedding supports longer legal terms and customer payback but brings product and installation complexity. Route-processing offers quicker incremental-customer payback and higher margins when density and owned treatment are strong, but it has greater route, vehicle, and plant utilization exposure.

METRIC	BENCHMARK RANGE	WHY THE ASSERTION MAKES SENSE	STRONGEST SUPPORT / CAVEAT
Revenue growth	Onsite system: 5% / 8% / 12% low-central-high. Route-processing: 6% / 9% / 13%.	Onsite growth comes from installed kitchens, chain wins, throughput, and price after removing commodity pass-through. Route growth reflects density, cross-sell, treatment throughput, and new accounts after excluding acquisitions.	RTI serves 45,000-plus kitchens through 41 depots but has no organic/commodity bridge. LES reaches 129,500 locations and 95 facility or partner sites; WRM and Wind River are active acquirers. Confidence: Onsite: Medium; route-processing: Medium
EBITDA margin	Onsite system: 18% / 21% / 25%. Route-processing: 22% / 28% / 32%, with an observed 18%-34% company range.	RTI benefits from sticky service and recovered-oil value but bears fresh-oil, installation, depot, and field costs. Route margin rises when dense collection feeds controlled treatment; mixed services or third-party disposal dilute it.	S&P supported ratings-adjusted EBITDA margins above 30% for LES, the cleanest disclosed route processor. RTI has no current standalone margin; Wind River's plumbing, residential, and specialty-service mix supports a lower 18%-26% company range. Confidence: Onsite: Medium-Low; route-processing: Medium-High
Maintenance capex / revenue	Onsite system: 2.5% / 3.5% / 4.5%. Route-processing: 3.5% / 5.0% / 6.5%.	RTI sustains installed tanks, pumps, filtration, monitoring, and vehicles; new installs are growth capex. Route processors replace vacuum trucks and maintain treatment, environmental, and safety systems.	RTI has 41 depots and 45,000-plus sites; LES reports 670 field vehicles; Wind River reports 1,000 vehicles and 16 plants. None discloses maintenance capex, so ranges use replacement cycles and asset intensity. Confidence: Onsite: Low; route-processing: Medium-Low
Post-maintenance capex conversion	Onsite system: 75% / 83% / 90%. Route-processing: 77% / 82% / 89%.	Both models convert recurring EBITDA well before financing, working capital, and growth capex. RTI maintains distributed equipment; route operators reserve cash for fleet and plants, with mixed platforms weakest.	The ranges are derived as (EBITDA - maintenance capex) / EBITDA. Company central cases are RTI 83%, LES 87%, WRM 83%, and Wind River 75%. S&P's RTI cash-burn commentary shows why this metric is not full equity cash flow. Confidence: Low-Medium for both archetypes because maintenance capex is inferred
Initial contract tenor	Onsite system: 3 / 4 / 5 years. Route-processing: 1 / 2 / 3 years, with an observed 0.5-3-year company range.	RTI likely needs a multi-year term to underwrite onsite equipment. Route service uses shorter commercial agreements, schedules, or callout relationships; renewal behavior matters more than lease-like lockup.	No company publishes a standard term. RTI emphasizes flexibility, not duration; LES and WRM describe recurring services, while Wind River's residential/local mix supports shorter arrangements. Confidence: Low for both archetypes; this is the report's lowest-confidence metric
Effective customer tenure	Onsite system: 6 / 9 / 12 years. Route-processing: 5 / 7 / 10 years.	Equipment, workflow, safety value, and the nuisance of manual oil handling make RTI sticky. Route customers stay because service recurs and reliability, compliance, and local disposal access matter, though switching is easier.	RTI has equipment embedded in more than 45,000 commercial kitchens. LES serves 129,500 locations; WRM bundles grease and adjacent services; Wind River retains trusted local brands across a 75-plus-year operating legacy. Cohort churn is not disclosed. Confidence: Medium for both archetypes
Utilization exposure	Onsite system: Moderate / Moderate / Moderate. Route-processing: Moderate / Moderate-High / High.	RTI equipment can remain deployed while oil throughput softens, so gallons per kitchen and depot density matter. Routes are more exposed to stops, gallons per haul, truck/technician productivity, and plant throughput.	RTI combines 45,000-plus installed kitchens with 41 depots. LES has 670 field vehicles; Wind River has 1,000 vehicles and plants processing more than 200 million gallons annually. Public route-fill and permitted-capacity utilization KPIs are unavailable. Confidence: Medium on classification; Low on exact KPI levels
New-unit / customer payback	Onsite system: 1.5 / 2.5 / 3.5 years. Route-processing: 0.5 / 1.25 / 2.25 years for an incremental customer in an existing dense market.	RTI recovers hardware, installation, acquisition, and route support from whole-relationship contribution. Nearby route customers leverage shared trucks and plants; de novo branches and acquisitions take longer.	RTI cites \$250 and nine labor hours of weekly customer savings, not unit contribution. LES, WRM, and Wind River share fleets and plants; the benchmark does not allocate a whole asset to one account. Confidence: Onsite: Low-Medium; route-processing: Medium-Low
B2B vs B2C	Onsite system: predominantly B2B across low-central-high. Route-processing: predominantly B2B / predominantly B2B / mixed B2B-B2C.	RTI sells to commercial kitchens and institutions. LES and most WRM customers are commercial or industrial. Wind River materially serves households alongside business, municipal, and industrial accounts, widening the route archetype's customer mix.	About 60% of RTI revenue was QSR-related in 2022. LES targets commercial/industrial generators; WRM names commercial/institutional users; Wind River serves homes, businesses, municipalities, and industry. Confidence: High

HOW TO READ THE UNIVERSE

The companies solve recurring, essential oil and wastewater problems, but the bottleneck asset differs. At RTI it is the installed customer-site system and oil workflow. In route-processing it is local density plus permitted treatment or disposal access. That difference drives margin, payback, legal term, and utilization.

Restaurant Technologies

What it does. Installs automated cooking-oil systems and provides fresh-oil delivery, filtration, monitoring, used-oil removal, and recycling, solving kitchen labor, safety, quality, and disposal problems.

Economic model. Unit: installed location; gallons measure usage and depot routes service capacity. Revenue mixes product, service, equipment, and recovery value. Equipment/workflow embedding retains customers; closures, operator changes, low throughput, service failures, or repricing cause churn. Capital funds onsite systems, vehicles, and depots.

Evidence bridge. 45,000-plus kitchens, 41 depots, 1,200-plus employees; about 60% of 2022 revenue was QSR-related. Margin, capex, terms, and payback are derived; S&P reported 2024 cash deficits despite durable revenue.

Liquid Environmental Solutions

What it does. Collects, transports, treats, recycles, and disposes of grease, used oil, wastewater, grit, and related streams for commercial/industrial customers needing recurring sanitation and compliance.

Economic model. Units: route customer for payback, truck/route for utilization, treatment plant for margin. Revenue mixes service, hauling, treatment/disposal, and recovery value. Plants and permits capture spread; recurring need, reliability, and processing access retain accounts. Poor service, pricing, dense rivals, or partner dependence create churn/margin risk.

Evidence bridge. 1,020 employees, 670 vehicles, 95 facility/partner sites, 129,500 locations; earlier 24 plants and 300-plus vacuum trucks. S&P supports margins above 30%. Owned/partner mix, organic growth, churn, and maintenance capex are unavailable.

Waste Resources Management

What it does. Grease-centered platform collecting, processing, transporting, and recycling liquid waste while cross-selling jetting, trap repair, plumbing, septic, sludge, and remediation to commercial/institutional sites.

Economic model. Unit: route customer linked to shared processing. Revenue mixes collection, treatment, recovery, transport, and field work. Vertical integration and bundled reliability retain accounts; switching remains easier than onsite equipment. Capital includes vacuum trucks, specialty units, pumps, tanks, and processing assets.

Evidence bridge. 10,000-plus clients, four states, 300-plus employees; a 2026 deal adds 13 metros. Mixed McDonald Farms services reduce purity. Central: 10% growth, 26% EBITDA, 4.5% maintenance capex, six-year tenure, 1.25-year incremental payback; capex confidence Low.

Wind River Environmental

What it does. East Coast consolidator spanning residential septic, commercial grease, plumbing/drains, municipal-industrial wastewater, specialty services, and treatment management, solving backup, compliance, and downtime risks.

Economic model. Unit: route/service customer; plants drive network margin. Revenue mixes routes, septic cycles, emergencies, and projects. Local trust, recurring need, disposal access, and response retain customers; service inconsistency, competition, and integration cause churn. Its varied fleet/plants create density but heavy maintenance and mixed-business exposure.

Evidence bridge. 1,100-plus experts, 1,000 vehicles, 100 teams, 16 states, 90-plus acquisitions, 16 plants processing 200 million-plus gallons. Central: 9% growth, 22% EBITDA, 5.5% maintenance capex, eight-year tenure, 1.5-year incremental payback. Only clearly mixed B2B-B2C company.

KEY DILIGENCE QUESTIONS

Obtain current standalone revenue and EBITDA for all four private companies and separate organic growth from acquisitions at LES, WRM, and Wind River. | Confirm contract forms, renewal mechanics, and cohort churn. Initial legal tenor is the lowest-confidence conclusion in the report. | Build maintenance capex by asset class: RTI onsite systems and service vehicles; route-company vacuum trucks, tanks, pumps, plants, and environmental and safety capital. | Clarify recovered-material accounting and commodity pass-through: fresh and used oil at RTI; internal treatment, partner routing, and recovery spreads at LES; recovered outputs at WRM and Wind River. | Preserve the payback distinction between an installed RTI location, an incremental dense-route customer, and a full new branch, plant, or acquisition.